

UNIFORMS OF CHASSEUR AND CUIRASSIER

Napoleon Bonaparte (see p.182) relied on his light cavalry (chasseurs) and heavy cavalry (cuirassiers) to mount charges and press home a decisive advantage in pursuing routed opponents. These are examples of the uniforms of the chasseurs and the cuirassiers. The chasseur uniform is that of the *1er Chasseurs à Cheval de la Ligne, 2e Compagnie*, from around 1806. The cuirassier was the descendant of the mounted and armoured medieval knight, and took his name from the *cuirasse* (armour breastplate) he wore. Napoleon found an important role for cuirassiers in his army at a time when the use of armoured heavy cavalry was declining.



Cockade in the red, white, and blue of the French tricolore

Chinscales, tied behind shako when not in use

▲ SHAKO

Date c.1806

Origin France

Material Felt, leather

The shako was adopted by many European cavalry and infantry regiments in the late 1700s. This chasseur shako had a waterproof top and was secured under the chin by brass chinscales.



▲ FULL DRESS SHAKO

Date c.1806

Origin France

Material Felt, leather

When on parade, the chasseur wore a plume on his shako instead of the pompom he wore when in battle. This is the full dress shako of the First Regiment of Chasseurs.



Forage cap (bonnet de police) rolled up and strapped to cartridge box

▲ CARTRIDGE BOX

Date c.1806

Origin France

Material Leather

The chasseur carried a box of prepared cartridges for his carbine and pistols. He hung the box from a crossbelt worn over the left shoulder.

► BREAD BAG

Date c.1806

Origin France

Material Linen

A lightweight cloth bag was used by the chasseurs to carry rations. They were not issued with water bottles and often had their own leather wineskin.



► CHASSEUR UNIFORM

Date c.1806

Origin France

Material Wool

Under the tight-fitting braided jacket, known as a dolman (originally from a Turkish word for a looser garment), the chasseur wore a splendid red waistcoat. A long white cotton shirt was tucked into the breeches and tied between his legs. The collar was fastened with an unobtrusive black stock.

► RIDING BOOTS

Date c.1806

Origin France

Material Leather

The well-made, tasselled cavalry boots of the chasseurs had iron or brass spurs on them. The boots were made of soft leather in the traditional style of the Hungarian hussar.

